

**FILM MAKING AND RADIO PODCASTING CD23731
REPORT**

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BONAFIDE CERTIFICATE

Certified that this report titled "Beyond the Shortcut – CD23731" is the bonafide work of LAKSHMI NARAYANI V (231701029) who carried out the work under my supervision. Certified further that to the best of my knowledge the work reported herein does not form part of any other thesis or dissertation on the basis of which a degree or award was conferred on an earlier occasion on this or any other candidate.

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CHAPTER 1

INTRODUCTION

Film making is a creative form of visual communication that combines storytelling, acting, cinematography, sound, lighting and editing to communicate an idea or experience to an audience. A short film presents a complete story within a limited duration, making it important to develop a clear concept and use every scene effectively. Radio podcasting, on the other hand, communicates stories through audio elements such as narration, dialogue, music, sound effects and silence. Both forms require creativity, planning and effective storytelling.

The project titled "BEYOND THE SHORTCUT" is a short fantasy and feel-good film developed as part of the Film Making and Radio Podcasting course. The story begins with a relatable situation in which a girl wakes up to a huge pending workload and wishes that someone would simply complete it for her. A single sneeze magically finishes a portion of her work, and she soon discovers that every sneeze she makes instantly completes whatever she is looking at.

The story takes an unexpected turn once the girl begins using this power freely. What starts as an exciting shortcut soon empties her plate of food, her biscuit and, eventually, her sense of achievement. She realises that finishing something instantly is not the same as experiencing it. A magical fairy then appears briefly to reaffirm this lesson, after which the girl chooses to return to her work and complete it through her own effort.

The project is designed not only as a visual short film but also as a story that can be adapted into a radio podcast. The visual elements of the film, especially the magical sneeze and the fairy's appearance, can be replaced by narration, sound design and voice performance in the podcast version.

CHAPTER 2

PROJECT OVERVIEW

The main idea of BEYOND THE SHORTCUT is to transform an ordinary, relatable morning into a light-hearted fantasy that carries a meaningful message about effort and experience. The first part of the film intentionally appears realistic and familiar. The audience sees the main character overwhelmed by pending work and assumes the story is simply about a stressful morning.

Once the magical sneeze begins completing her tasks, the tone shifts into fantasy and comedy. The audience enjoys the girl's excitement as she discovers her new power, before the story gradually turns reflective when she realises that skipping effort also skips joy. The appearance of the fairy provides a gentle, magical resolution, and the final scenes return the story to a warm, feel-good tone as the girl chooses to work honestly.

The film uses a single main location, a small number of characters and easily available objects such as a notebook, a laptop and everyday food items. This makes the project practical to produce while still allowing comedic timing, fantasy elements and emotional storytelling to be demonstrated.

CHAPTER 3

TITLE – BEYOND THE SHORTCUT

The title "BEYOND THE SHORTCUT" is directly connected to the central idea of the story. At the beginning, the "shortcut" refers to the magical sneeze that instantly completes the girl's pending work, offering an easy escape from effort.

However, the meaning of the title deepens as the story progresses. The girl discovers that a shortcut can finish a task but cannot provide the satisfaction, learning or experience that comes from doing it herself. The word "beyond" therefore points to what lies past the convenience of a shortcut — the value, growth and happiness that only genuine effort can offer.

CHAPTER 4

GENRE

The film belongs to the fantasy and feel-good genre, with light comedic elements woven through a moral storyline. The fantasy element is introduced through the magical sneeze and the appearance of the fairy, while the feel-good tone is maintained through warm visuals, humour and a positive resolution.

The comedy is created through the girl's exaggerated reactions and casual, conversational Tamil dialogue, while the emotional depth comes from her quiet realisation that shortcuts cannot replace genuine effort. The audience experiences the story alongside the girl, discovering the power and its consequences at the same pace she does.

The major elements used in the film are:

- An overwhelming pending workload
- A magical, wish-granting sneeze
- Instantly disappearing tasks
- Disappearing food and small joys
- A quiet moment of self-realisation
- A magical fairy and her gentle message
- A warm, feel-good resolution

CHAPTER 5

OBJECTIVES

The main objective of the project is to create an engaging fantasy and feel-good short film using simple filmmaking techniques and a single production setup. The project also aims to demonstrate how comedic timing, lighting, editing and sound can be combined to convey both humour and a meaningful message.

The specific objectives are:

- To develop an original short-film story with a clear moral message.
- To understand screenplay and scene development for a fantasy narrative.
- To practice camera framing and shot composition for comedic and emotional beats.
- To use lighting to distinguish ordinary moments from magical ones.
- To create a sense of wonder through editing and sound design.
- To develop basic video editing skills, including transition and disappearance effects.
- To understand the importance of background music and sound effects in fantasy storytelling.
- To adapt the story into a radio podcast format.
- To understand the difference between visual and audio storytelling.

CHAPTER 6

STORY DEVELOPMENT

The story was developed around the simple idea of a person wishing their work would complete itself, and then discovering that this wish comes at a hidden cost. The initial concept was kept light-hearted and relatable so that the fantasy element could be introduced naturally, without requiring multiple locations or a large cast.

The first part establishes the character and her ordinary, slightly stressful morning. The accidental sneeze introduces the magical element in a way that feels natural rather than forced. This allows the girl, and the audience, to discover the power gradually rather than all at once.

The middle part was developed to build excitement and comedy as the girl experiments with her new ability, before slowly turning the tone reflective once she notices that her happiness is disappearing along with her tasks and food. The fairy's appearance was placed near the end to gently confirm the lesson the girl has already begun to understand herself, and the final scene was developed to show her choosing effort over convenience.

CHAPTER 7

STORY SYNOPSIS

The story follows a girl who wakes up on an ordinary morning to find a notebook full of pending work. Frustrated by the sheer amount of it, she wishes that someone could simply do it for her. Moments later, she sneezes loudly, and everything briefly goes silent.

When the alarm rings again, she is confused, believing she has overslept. She returns to her table to begin working, but when she sneezes once more, she notices that the task in front of her has already been completed. Shocked and delighted, she tests the sneeze again, and another piece of work disappears from her list.

Realising she now holds a magical shortcut, the girl begins using her sneeze freely, celebrating as her workload rapidly shrinks. However, when she casually sneezes near her food and then her biscuit, both vanish instantly. Her excitement fades as she stares at the empty plate, unable to understand why finishing everything so quickly has left her feeling empty rather than happy.

Sitting quietly, she reflects on everything she has skipped and realises that struggle is what allows a person to learn and grow. She understands that a shortcut can remove the task, but it also removes the experience and satisfaction that come with genuinely completing it.

At this moment, a magical fairy gently appears beside her, delivering a short and meaningful message: that everything eventually returns to how it should be, and that the outcome lies in her own hands. The fairy smiles and disappears in a soft magical glow.

The girl smiles, understanding the message fully. She turns back to her notebook and begins her work again, this time willingly and without shortcuts, recognising that a life shortcut cannot replace every part of the journey. The film closes on a montage of her working, learning and smiling, followed by the message that success means more when it is experienced rather than skipped.

CHAPTER 8

CHARACTERS

The main character of the film is a young girl who begins the story overwhelmed by her pending work. She is initially frustrated and eager for an easy way out, and her emotional journey moves from excitement, to confusion, to quiet reflection and finally to willing acceptance of effort. Her expressions and reactions are central to the film because the audience experiences the fantasy element and its consequences almost entirely through her responses.

The second character is the magical fairy, who appears briefly near the end of the film. She is not given an elaborate backstory; instead, she functions as a gentle guiding presence who reinforces the lesson the girl has already begun to understand. Her calm and warm demeanour contrasts with the girl's earlier excitement and confusion, and her brief appearance is designed to feel reassuring rather than mysterious.

CHAPTER 9

SCENE DEVELOPMENT

9.1 Scene 1 – The Assignment

The first scene introduces the main character and her ordinary morning. Her alarm rings, she wakes up, gets ready and sits at her table with a notebook and laptop. She opens the notebook to find a large amount of pending work and reacts with frustration, wishing aloud that someone could do it for her. A sudden, exaggerated sneeze interrupts the moment, and everything abruptly goes silent before cutting to black.

The purpose of this scene is to establish a relatable, everyday atmosphere before the fantasy elements begin. Wider and medium shots can be used to show the room and the notebook, with a closer shot on her frustrated expression.

9.2 Scene 2 – The First Magic

The alarm rings again, and the girl wakes up confused, believing she has simply overslept. She freshens up and returns to her table to begin working. When she sneezes again, she notices, to her surprise, that the assignment in front of her has already been completed.

This scene acts as the turning point where the fantasy element is confirmed, moving the story from an ordinary morning into a magical premise.

9.3 Scene 3 – The Sneeze Experiment

The girl looks around in disbelief and pinches herself to check whether she is dreaming. She deliberately sneezes again, and another piece of work disappears from her list. Delighted, she repeats the sneeze intentionally, watching her workload shrink further, and begins celebrating happily.

This scene can use quick cuts between her notebook and her excited reactions, building comedic energy as she embraces her newfound shortcut.

9.4 Scene 4 – The Shortcut

Realising she can use the sneeze for anything, the girl casually sneezes near her plate of food, which instantly disappears. Surprised, she picks up a biscuit, sneezes again, and it too vanishes. Staring at her now-empty plate, her earlier happiness slowly fades into a quiet, uncertain silence.

The shift in tone here should be gradual, moving from comedic celebration to a slower, more reflective pace as she begins to sense something is wrong.

9.5 Scene 5 – *The Realisation*

The girl looks around her room, thinking about everything she has skipped. She acknowledges to herself that struggle is what allows a person to learn something new, and that by using the shortcut for everything, she has also skipped the very experience that would have made her happy.

This scene relies primarily on quiet dialogue and facial expression rather than action, allowing the audience to reflect along with her.

9.6 Scene 6 – *Fairy Appears*

As the girl looks up, a magical fairy gently flies into the frame from the side and lands beside her. Surprised, the girl watches as the fairy delivers a short, meaningful line about everything returning to how it should be, with the outcome resting in the girl's own hands. The fairy smiles and disappears in a soft magical glow.

This scene is the emotional and visual centrepiece of the film and can use soft, warm lighting along with subtle visual effects to mark the fairy's arrival and departure.

9.7 Scene 7 – *Final Realisation*

The girl smiles slightly, reflecting on how she had wanted to finish everything quickly, but now understands that effort itself gives meaning to the outcome. She turns back to her notebook and begins her work again, this time willingly and without relying on the shortcut.

This scene marks her transformation from seeking convenience to embracing genuine effort.

9.8 Scene 8 – *Final Quote*

The film closes with a montage of the girl working, learning, making small mistakes and smiling through the process. A closing voiceover and on-screen text present the message that success means more when it is experienced rather than skipped, before the screen cuts to black.

CHAPTER 10

CLIMAX AND ENDING

The climax occurs when the girl, having realised that her shortcut has cost her both her food and her sense of achievement, is visited by the magical fairy. The fairy's brief appearance and gentle message act as the emotional turning point that confirms what the girl has already begun to understand on her own.

The use of a calm, reassuring fairy rather than a dramatic confrontation keeps the tone of the film warm and feel-good even at its most reflective moment. The ending is resolved rather than open-ended: the girl consciously chooses to return to her work through genuine effort, reinforcing the film's central message.

CHAPTER 11

CINEMATOGRAPHY

Cinematography is used to distinguish the ordinary and magical portions of the story. During the first part of the film, normal and slightly frantic camera movements can reflect the girl's morning stress. As the sneeze magic is discovered, quicker cuts and close-up shots on the notebook and her expressions can heighten the comedic excitement.

Close-up shots are particularly useful for the notebook, the disappearing food, and the girl's changing facial expressions from excitement to confusion to quiet reflection. A gentle, slightly slower camera movement can be introduced during the fairy's appearance to give the moment a magical, floating quality.

The camera can remain lively and quick-paced during the comedic sneeze sequences and become calmer and more stable during the reflective and fairy scenes, guiding the audience's emotional response alongside the character's.

CHAPTER 12

LIGHTING

Lighting plays an important role in separating the ordinary and magical moods of the film. The morning scenes can use natural, slightly warm daylight to establish a familiar and relatable setting.

As the sneeze magic begins, lighting can subtly brighten around the completed tasks to draw attention to the change. During the fairy's appearance, a soft, warm glow can be introduced around her to visually mark the magical presence, gradually fading as she disappears.

Returning to natural lighting in the final scene reinforces the idea that the girl has returned to her genuine, grounded effort after the fantasy interlude.

CHAPTER 13

SOUND DESIGN

Sound is central to BEYOND THE SHORTCUT because the magical sneeze itself is an audio-driven trigger for every transformation in the story.

Normal scenes can include the alarm ringtone, pages turning and room ambience to establish the realistic morning setting. The exaggerated sneeze sound effect becomes the signature cue of the film, followed by a brief magical chime or whoosh each time a task or object disappears.

Silence is also deliberately used, particularly in the moment after the food disappears and during the girl's quiet reflection, allowing the audience to sit with her realisation before the fairy's gentle, warm-toned voice and background music return.

Important sound elements include:

- Alarm ringtone
- Notebook page-turning sound
- Exaggerated sneeze sound effect
- Magical chime or whoosh
- Sudden silence
- Warm background score during the fairy scene
- Soft magical glow sound cue
- Closing voiceover

CHAPTER 14

EDITING TECHNIQUES

Video editing is central to the concept of BEYOND THE SHORTCUT because the story relies on visually communicating instant, magical change.

The editing process can include quick cuts, jump cuts and disappearance effects to show tasks, food and objects vanishing immediately after each sneeze. During the comedic sequences, fast-paced cuts between the girl's actions and reactions can heighten the humour.

For the reflective and fairy sequences, editing slows down considerably, using longer takes and gentle cross-dissolves to mark the fairy's arrival and departure. A soft glow or light-flare transition effect can be used specifically for the fairy's appearance and disappearance.

CHAPTER 15

USE OF PROPS AND LOCATION

The project is designed to be produced using a single simple location and easily available props.

The main location is a bedroom or study room where the girl works.

The major props required are:

- Notebook and pen
- Laptop
- Study table and chair
- Plate of food and a biscuit
- Alarm clock or phone alarm
- Fairy costume or simple visual-effect element

The limited number of props makes the film practical to shoot while allowing the focus to remain on the character's expressions and the magical transformations.

CHAPTER 16

RADIO PODCAST ADAPTATION

The same story can be adapted into a radio podcast by removing the visual dependency and replacing visual information with audio descriptions and sound effects.

In the short film, the audience can see tasks and food disappearing after each sneeze. In the podcast, the same action must be communicated through narration and sound. For example, the narrator can describe the notebook page turning blank while a magical chime plays immediately after the sneeze sound effect.

The fairy's appearance, which relies heavily on visual glow effects in the film, must instead be conveyed through a distinct, warm voice, gentle background music and a soft magical sound cue. This demonstrates the importance of sound imagination in radio storytelling for fantasy content.

CHAPTER 17

RADIO PODCAST SCRIPT APPROACH

The podcast version can begin with a narrator describing the girl waking up and discovering her pending work, with the alarm and page-turning sounds establishing the setting.

When the sneeze occurs, the sound effect is immediately followed by a magical chime, and the narrator describes the task disappearing. As the girl experiments further, the pace of narration can quicken to match her growing excitement, before slowing down once the food disappears.

During the reflective scene, narration becomes softer and slower, supported by gentle, minimal background music. The fairy's dialogue can be introduced with a distinct reverb or tonal shift to separate her voice from the girl's, and the podcast can end with the closing voiceover message followed by a moment of warm, quiet music before fading out.

CHAPTER 18

VOICE AND AUDIO PERFORMANCE

Voice acting is important for the podcast version because the audience depends entirely on sound to understand the emotions of the characters.

The girl's voice should move naturally through several emotional stages: frustrated at the start, excited and comedic during the sneeze experiments, quiet and reflective after the food disappears, and warm and accepting by the end.

The fairy's voice should be distinctly calm, warm and gentle, using a softer tone or subtle reverb to set her apart from the girl's voice and to reinforce her role as a magical, reassuring presence.

The following elements are important:

- Clear pronunciation of conversational Tamil dialogue
- Appropriate comedic timing and pauses
- Emotional voice modulation across the story's arc
- A distinct, calm voice for the fairy
- Controlled speaking speed during reflective moments
- Appropriate background music
- Effective use of silence after the food disappears

CHAPTER 19

PRODUCTION PROCESS

The production of the project can be divided into three stages: pre-production, production and post-production.

During pre-production, the story idea was developed and converted into a screenplay. The scenes, characters, location, props and required sound effects were identified, and the balance between comedy and reflection was planned so that the tone would shift naturally across the film.

During production, the scenes are recorded according to the screenplay. Reaction shots of the girl are captured from multiple angles to support the comedic and emotional beats, and the fairy's brief scene is recorded with attention to lighting and movement so that visual-effect elements can be added smoothly. Voice recordings for the podcast are also prepared.

During post-production, the recorded footage is organised and edited. Disappearance effects, the magical glow around the fairy, sound effects, background music and the closing text are added. The final video is exported after checking the complete sequence and timing.

CHAPTER 20

CHALLENGES FACED

One of the major challenges in producing a fantasy film with a simple setup is creating convincing magical moments, such as objects instantly disappearing and the fairy's appearance, without access to advanced visual-effects tools.

Another challenge is balancing tone: the film needs to remain comedic and light-hearted during the sneeze sequences while still delivering a genuine emotional message during the reflective scenes and the fairy's appearance, without the shift feeling abrupt.

Audio-visual synchronisation is also important, since the sneeze sound effect, the disappearance effect and the reaction shot must all align precisely to make the magic feel convincing and comedic timing must be preserved throughout editing.

CHAPTER 21

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Through this project, several practical skills can be developed. The project provides experience in screenplay writing, comedic scene planning, camera operation, lighting, acting, sound recording and video editing, particularly around achieving convincing disappearance and magical-glow effects.

The project also demonstrates the importance of tonal control in storytelling, since the film moves from comedy to reflection to a warm resolution within a short duration. A single well-placed pause or sound cue can communicate an emotional shift as effectively as a longer dramatic sequence.

The radio podcast adaptation provides additional experience in voice acting, narration and audio editing, and it demonstrates how a visually driven fantasy premise must be reimagined entirely through sound for an audio medium.

CHAPTER 22

EXPECTED OUTCOME

The final outcome of the project is a short fantasy and feel-good film titled BEYOND THE SHORTCUT, supported by a radio podcast adaptation of the same story. The film is expected to engage the audience through a light-hearted premise that gradually transitions into a warm and meaningful message about the value of effort and experience.

The project demonstrates the practical use of comedic timing, visual storytelling, sound design and editing techniques within a fantasy narrative. The resolved, feel-good conclusion is intended to leave the audience with a clear and relatable takeaway rather than an ambiguous ending.

CHAPTER 23

CONCLUSION

The BEYOND THE SHORTCUT project demonstrates how a simple, relatable premise can be developed into an engaging fantasy short film through effective use of film-making techniques. The story begins with an ordinary morning and pending workload and gradually introduces a magical shortcut, before guiding both the character and the audience toward a meaningful realisation about effort and experience.

The project combines screenplay writing, acting, cinematography, lighting, sound design and video editing. Each element contributes to building the film's comedic energy as well as its emotional resolution. The use of a single location and a small cast also demonstrates that an effective short film does not necessarily require complex production resources.

The radio podcast adaptation further demonstrates how a visually driven fantasy story can be transferred from a visual medium to an audio medium. Elements that are shown on screen, such as the disappearing objects and the fairy's magical glow, must instead be communicated through narration, dialogue, sound effects, music and silence.

Overall, BEYOND THE SHORTCUT provides practical experience in both film making and radio podcasting while reinforcing the message that success means more when it is genuinely experienced rather than shortcut.

"Success means more when you experience it."